



MARKETING LABS · IMPACT & RESEARCH

Evidence Strength Ladder

Say what the evidence supports—no more, no less.

Evidence Strength Ladder: assess what research evidence supports, what cannot yet be claimed and what is needed to progress toward corroborated impact.

Includes: framework reference · guidance by Primary use · printable worksheet

Evidence Strength Ladder: reference

RESEARCH COMMUNICATION AND IMPACT PROTOTYPE

Place a research claim on a practical evidence ladder. See what can responsibly be said now, what still cannot be claimed, what evidence would strengthen the case, and how to write about it without turning activity or reach into proof of societal impact.

Evidence of activity is not automatically evidence of impact. A publication, dataset, media mention, event, download or positive comment may matter, but it does not alone demonstrate that research changed policy, practice, behaviour or wider outcomes.

Evidence position

Selected stage: Pattern or association. The evidence checklist currently supports Stage 2 as the conservative default.

Pattern or association

Responsible current claim

Urban heat and neighbourhood design: Analysis of Leicester neighbourhoods suggests that lower tree canopy and more impervious surfaces are associated with higher daytime land surface temperatures.

WHAT CAN RESPONSIBLY BE SAID

You can describe an observed trend, comparison or association, using appropriately qualified language such as “is associated with”, “suggests” or “was observed alongside”.

WHAT CANNOT YET BE CLAIMED

Do not present association as proof of causation, claim that the finding has changed a decision, or imply that a societal benefit has already occurred.

EVIDENCE NEEDED TO PROGRESS

Develop and test a credible pathway from the finding to potential use; examine alternative explanations, uncertainty, context and stakeholder relevance.

EXAMPLE WORDING

Reviewer questions

- ! Does the wording distinguish association, correlation or pattern from causation?
- ! What alternative explanations, confounders or data limitations need to be acknowledged?
- ! Who needs to interpret the finding alongside local, professional or lived experience?
- ! What decision or question could the finding inform, without overclaiming its authority?

Next evidence steps

- Evidence present — Stage 1: Retain an approved, traceable research output, data source, method or observation record.
- Evidence present — Stage 2: Document the analysis, trend, comparison or association and its scope.
- ! Evidence gap — Stage 3: Set out and test a credible pathway explaining how the research could contribute to use or change.

- ! Evidence gap — Stage 4: Collect dated records showing who used the research, how and for what purpose.
- ! Evidence gap — Stage 5: Collect evidence of what changed in understanding, capacity, practice, policy, behaviour or service.
- ! Evidence gap — Stage 6: Secure independent external evidence that corroborates the specific benefit or impact claim.

Interpretation safeguard

Known limitations supplied for this claim: The analysis measures land surface temperature, not indoor temperature or individual heat exposure. The findings are associative and do not establish direct causation. Further local validation and community input are needed before prioritising interventions. Keep the claim at the pattern or association level unless the evidence trail justifies a stronger statement.

Guidance by Primary use

Funding proposal or impact plan

The analysis suggests a pattern that may inform further investigation and engagement with relevant stakeholders.

Research report or evaluation

Within the study scope, [finding] was associated with [related factor]. This does not by itself establish causation.

Public-facing webpage

The research suggests a relationship between [topic] and [factor], helping identify questions for further local investigation.

Impact case study

The work identified an evidence-based pattern that created a basis for discussion, validation and possible application.

Policy or partner briefing

The analysis identifies an association that may be relevant to [decision area], subject to contextual interpretation and further validation.

Evidence Strength Ladder: your canvas

Print this page or fill it in by hand. The interactive lab asks the same questions.

Project, research or initiative

For example: Urban heat and neighbourhood design

Claim you want to make

Avoid adding causal language unless you have appropriate evidence for causation.

Primary use

- ☐ Funding proposal or impact plan
 ☐ Research report or evaluation
 ☐ Public-facing webpage
 ☐ Impact case study
 ☐ Policy or partner briefing

data-evidence

- ☐ Yes
 ☐ No

pattern-evidence

- ☐ Yes
 ☐ No

contribution-evidence

- ☐ Yes
 ☐ No

use-evidence

- ☐ Yes
 ☐ No

change-evidence

- ☐ Yes
 ☐ No

corroboration-evidence

- ☐ Yes
 ☐ No

Evidence notes or sources

Add outputs, partner feedback, records, references, metrics or sources you have.

Known caveats or limits

Add assumptions, uncertainty, scope limitations or alternative explanations.

Planning aid, not advice. Test assumptions with evidence and consider privacy, accessibility, fairness and sustainability before acting.